



Shock exit: Gauff's erratic game let her down against Svitolina (facing page) in the quarterfinal. AFP

on the court.)

Although Anisimova battled back from a 4-1 deficit in the second set, she appeared hyper-emotional and occasionally distraught. But credit Pegula (**right**) for much of that anxiety. "We're not seeing a one-dimensional game from Pegula anymore," said *ESPN* analyst Mary Joe Fernandez. "Her serve has been so accurate. This is the best I've ever seen her play."

In the remaining quarterfinal, Rybakina overpowered former No. 1 Swiatek 7-5, 6-1, displaying her dramatically improved forehand and kick second serve. "Rybakina dominated every aspect of the game, especially serve return," said all-time great Martina Navratilova, a *Tennis Channel* analyst. "Players are on to how Swiatek plays. And she's not sure what she has to do to improve." Although finesse is not the 24-year-old Polish superstar's forte, she could and should broaden her predictable game by volleying more.

Rybakina faced a somewhat tougher test in the semifinals against Pegula. The improved American is a skilful counterpuncher who can redirect opponents' shots with the best of them. But she lacks the shot power, especially on both serves, height at 5'7", the foot speed and the topspin to capture a Grand Slam title. Although Pegula valiantly fended off three match points and had two set points in the fluctuating tie-breaker, Rybakina exploited Pegula's vulnerabilities to close out a 6-3, 7-6(7) triumph with a 114-mph ace and backhand serve return winner.

Ice trumps fire

The oddsmakers gave Sabalenka a 62 per cent to 38 per cent edge over Rybakina in the final. Paul Annacone, a *Tennis Channel* analyst and former coach of superstar Pete Sampras, saw beyond the Xs and Os, recalling Sabalenka's heartbreaking three-set setbacks in momentous matches at Grand Slam events. "If you have scar tissue from the past, it never really goes away," said Annacone.

Much like a duel between Serena and her sister Venus in their primes, this Grand Slam final featured power tennis from start to finish. With the roof closed on Rod Laver Arena during the rainy Melbourne evening, the indoor conditions accentuated the aggressive games of Sabalenka, the crowd favourite, and Rybakina.

Sabalenka opened with her trademark serve-plus-one tactic — a slice wide and a forehand winner into the open court. Then she smacked an ace. Rybakina countered with a rocket forehand serve return winner. The battle was joined. Winners and forced errors would highlight this slugfest. When the 6' Kazakh broke serve for 1-0, *ESPN* analyst Fernandez said, "This is almost like a men's match. A break can almost cost you the set."

That break would cost Sabalenka the set, but not before Rybakina weathered a storm in the dramatic eighth game.

With the Kazakh down two break points serving at 15-40, coach Vukov exhorted, "Two big serves!" Rybakina responded with three big ones to escape and lead ad-in before forcing a backhand error to hold serve for 5-3. Two games later, the calm Kazakh wrapped up the 6-4 set. Remarkably, it was the first set Sabalenka had lost in the young season.

What wasn't surprising, though, was the clean ball striking of Rybakina in almost every shot or her massive first serve. Last year she led the WTA Tour in aces, while averaging 115 mph compared to 104 mph for the rest of the top 10. In Melbourne, it produced 41 aces (against only five double faults) going into this final. The Kazakh's rhythmical second serve has also become the best on the tour because of its huge six-foot-high kick — compared to five-foot-one for the Belarusian's — and superior accuracy. It bedevilled Sabalenka throughout the match.

Born in Moscow, Rybakina was trained by the Russian Tennis Federation, which refused to give her the requisite funding, so she switched national allegiance to tennis-loving Kazakhstan, which did. "This was a big



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